followed by a momentous visit to India by President Clinton in 2000 – the first by an American president in more than two decades.

Bilateral cooperation accelerated in the 2000s as interests converged. The September 2001 attacks on the United States, and the attack on Indian Parliament by Pakistani gunmen later that year, spurred Indo–US cooperation on counter-terrorism measures, leading to regional security dialogues as well as US pressure on Pakistan to curb cross-border attacks. Despite a massive upsurge in American aid to Pakistan as part of the US-led war on terror, that relationship remained rocky and did not substantially hinder a closer US relationship with India. Conflict with Pakistan would devastate India's economy and thus under-cut increasing US interest in India as a balance to China. More broadly, the closer US–Indian relationship is a reflection of increasing US support for India as a regional power-broker and of progress in cooperation over India's nuclear programme. The year 2005 marked a significant turning point in the relationship. In the course of that year, India and the United States finalised the Next Steps in Strategic Partnership initiative, which expanded bilateral cooperation and commerce in space, civilian nuclear activities, and high-technology trade, and they signed a landmark defence agreement calling for bilateral military exercises, an expansion of two-way defence trade and an increase in intelligence-sharing. Perhaps the most substantial pivot came with the unveiling of a new framework for nuclear cooperation in 2005, which led to the 2008 US–India Civil Nuclear Agreement and reversed India's status as a nuclear pariah.[24] The enthusiasm of the 2000s waned somewhat at the turn of the decade, but bilateral relations have retained importance on both sides, particularly with the US strategic pivot to Asia under the Obama administration. The signals sent out by the Obama administration in its first two years,